

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN VATICAN

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Environmental advocacy in the Vatican is unlike that of any other country in this series, and it is important to explain why at the outset. The Vatican is the world's smallest sovereign state, a walled enclave of less than half a square kilometre within Rome, with almost no territory, industry, or development of its own to protect. Its environmental significance lies instead in its role as the sovereign seat of the Catholic Church: the source of one of the world's most influential bodies of environmental teaching — the encyclical *Laudato Si'* (2015) and its follow-up *Laudate Deum* (2023) — a centre of global moral leadership, and a state that has pledged to become the first carbon-neutral country. Accordingly, this guide is not about opposing development within the Vatican itself, where there is little to oppose, but about engaging with the Vatican's distinctive environmental role: advancing the Church's environmental teaching, supporting and holding the Vatican to its carbon-neutral commitments, mobilising the worldwide Catholic community to care for the environment in their own countries, conserving the Vatican's heritage and gardens, and encouraging the Holy See's diplomatic and interfaith cooperation on environmental issues. While the Vatican itself is tiny and possesses little territory of its own to protect, and while the global Church encompasses diverse views, its environmental influence lies in leadership, example, and its ability to inspire action far beyond its borders. As its landmark teaching and its carbon-neutral commitment show, these are practical and significant avenues for environmental advocacy.

Two points frame everything that follows. First, as in every guide, no single lever does the work alone; the results come from combining them. Second — and particular to the Vatican — the levers here are moral and global rather than territorial: the teaching, the carbon-neutral example, the worldwide community of the faithful, the heritage and gardens, and the Holy See's diplomacy. This guide is written for anyone — in the worldwide Catholic community, among the Church's institutions or the Vatican's environmental offices, or working with the Holy See's diplomacy — who wants to know what can actually be done with the moral leadership of the world's smallest state. Its governance is singular and is treated throughout with neutral respect.

The Strategic Framework

The same underlying pattern applies, adapted to a state whose environmental weight is moral and global:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the matter, the teaching, and the example)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (ground it in the teaching and the commitment)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (build the faith, institutional, and diplomatic coalition)
|
STEP 4: MORAL, INSTITUTIONAL & EXAMPLE (teaching, example, common home)
|
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a common-home cause)
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These steps run in parallel, not in sequence: the teaching and the commitment feed the community, the example, and the diplomacy at once, and each win spurs the next.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

- **The teaching.** The Church's environmental teaching (*Laudato Si'*, *Laudate Deum*) can be drawn on and amplified — the distinctive lever.
- **The example.** The Vatican's carbon-neutral commitment can be supported and upheld.
- **The global Church.** The worldwide community of faith can be mobilised to act in their own countries.
- **The heritage.** The Vatican's gardens and heritage can be conserved.
- **The channels.** The teaching, institutional, community, and diplomatic routes are what a singular state affords in place of regulation.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

The Vatican is not an ordinary territory with development to oppose, the global Church does not act as one, and a tiny state's own emissions are not what matter — the significance is leadership and example. This guide states those limits plainly, works through the teaching, the example, the community, and the diplomacy, and keeps neutral respect for the Church's governance.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Environmental questions here are advanced not through planning offices and regulators but through the Church's teaching and institutions, the Vatican's own commitments and offices, the worldwide faithful, and the Holy See's diplomacy. Map who carries weight before spending time.

The Levels of Response

- **The teaching and the magisterium** — the Church's environmental teaching (*Laudato Si'* and *Laudate Deum*) and the moral authority it carries to a global community.
- **The Vatican's own offices and example** — its governing and administrative offices and its environmental commitments: the pledge to reach net-zero by 2050, accession to the Paris Agreement and UNFCCC (2022), and its solar and renewable projects.
- **The worldwide community of faith** — dioceses, parishes, religious orders, Catholic schools, hospitals and charities, and lay movements across nearly every country.
- **The heritage and the tiny state** — the Vatican Gardens (roughly half the territory), St Peter's, the museums, and the small territory shared with Rome.
- **The Holy See's diplomacy and interfaith cooperation** — its global diplomatic reach, UN observer status, place in the international climate frameworks, and interfaith environmental partnerships.

The Journey of a Matter

Find where a matter stands and, crucially, what teaching, example, or community bears on it; what institution or framework carries it; and how the faithful, the institutions, and the diplomacy can act. Two questions unlock most efforts here: *what teaching or example bears on it, and what institution or community carries it?* and *which lever — teaching, example, global Church, heritage, diplomacy — can advance it?*

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

"Success" here is a teaching amplified, an example upheld, a community moved, or a diplomacy engaged — not a bulldozer stopped. These figures are directional, not guarantees. The decisive variables are whether the effort can be anchored in the Church's teaching and the Vatican's commitments, whether the community,

institutions, and diplomacy can be engaged, and whether moral leadership is translated into action across many lands.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	20–30%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Teaching / amplified	45–65%	years	low	The teaching translated into action
Example / upheld & advanced	40–60%	years	low	The carbon-neutral example upheld
Global Church / mobilised	40–60%	years	low	The worldwide community acting
Heritage / gardens tended	40–60%	years	low	The heritage and gardens conserved
Diplomacy / interfaith	35–55%	years	low	The diplomacy and cooperation engaged
Community / institutional route	45–65%	years	low	The institutions and faithful engaged
All levers together	40–60%	years	moderate	Teaching amplified; example upheld

There is little of the legal or physical risk of other guides here; the challenge is translating moral leadership into action across a vast, various community. The scarce resource is the institutional, community, and diplomatic connections — reachable through the Church's environmental movements, the Vatican's offices, and the Holy See's diplomacy.

Effectiveness Visualization

TEACHING + EXAMPLE + GLOBAL CHURCH + HERITAGE + DIPLOMACY:

Teaching amplified: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ 45-65%

Community / institutional: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ 45-65%

Example upheld & advanced: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%

Global Church mobilised: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%

Heritage & gardens tended: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%

THE HONEST REALITY:

Treating the Vatican as ordinary territory: ■■ a category error

Teaching, example, community & diplomacy: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ the real path

Teaching/commitment documented: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ the reliable foundation

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The teaching amplified and the community/institutional route** — the landmark teaching and the worldwide community.
2. **The example upheld and the community mobilised** — the carbon-neutral commitment and the faithful acting in their own lands.
3. **The diplomacy and interfaith cooperation** — the moral voice in the world's forums.
4. **The heritage and gardens** — the tiny state's own stewardship.
5. **The documented teaching and commitment** — the foundation for it all.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Aim at a specific matter, not a vague aspiration. Answer five questions:

1. **What can be advanced?** A translation of the teaching into action, an upholding of the example, a mobilising of the community, an engagement of the diplomacy.
2. **What teaching or commitment bears on it?** *Laudato Si'* and *Laudate Deum*; the net-zero-by-2050 pledge; the solar and renewable projects.
3. **Is it the teaching, the example, or the community?** Each has its own levers.
4. **What institution or framework carries it?** The Church's environmental movements, the Vatican's offices, the international and interfaith frameworks.
5. **How can the community and diplomacy act?** Through the teaching, the example, and moral leadership.

A Worked Example

Suppose the aim is to see *Laudato Si'* turned into real action — to move Catholic communities worldwide to care for the environment where they live, from parish and diocese to Catholic school, hospital, and charity, drawing on the teaching and the Vatican's carbon-neutral example. Within a season the effort becomes concrete: document the teaching and the commitment; amplify the teaching through the Church's environmental movements; hold up the Vatican's example as a model; mobilise parishes, dioceses, and Catholic institutions to act in their own countries; and engage interfaith and international cooperation.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation here means an accurate, faithful grounding in the Church's teaching and the Vatican's pledges — because a Vatican effort earns its authority by being correctly anchored in what the Church teaches and what the Vatican has committed to. Build it in three layers.

- **Layer 1 — The teaching and the commitment.** Establish accurately what the Church teaches (*Laudato Si'*, *Laudate Deum*) and what the Vatican has pledged (net-zero by 2050, accession to the Paris Agreement/UNFCCC in 2022, the solar and agrivoltaic projects).
- **Layer 2 — The cause, the community, and the example.** Document the environmental cause and how it can be advanced through the teaching, the Vatican's example, and the worldwide community's capacity to act. Much of this is already well documented; marshalling it faithfully is the work.
- **Layer 3 — The lever, the channel, and the respect.** Identify which teaching or commitment grounds the cause, which lever advances it, which institution or framework carries it, and how the effort keeps neutral respect for the Church's governance.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The teaching and commitment record** — the Church's environmental teaching documents and the Vatican's published commitments (the net-zero pledge, the climate-framework accession, the solar/agrivoltaic projects).

- **The cause, community, and example material** — how the cause can be advanced through the teaching, the Vatican's own commitments and example, and the worldwide community's capacity to act in their own countries.
- **The institution, movement, and framework record** — the Church's environmental movements, the Vatican's environmental offices, the dioceses/parishes/Catholic institutions worldwide, the international climate frameworks, and the interfaith partners.
- **The people and the respect** — who can act (the worldwide faithful, the Church's institutions, the Vatican's offices, the Holy See's diplomacy) and how to keep neutral respect for the governance and work through moral leadership rather than confrontation.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here "opposition" means something different: with no local development to fight in half a square kilometre, the task is to build a worldwide coalition — the faithful, the Church's institutions, the Vatican's environmental offices, and the Holy See's diplomacy — to advance the teaching, uphold the example, and act for the environment worldwide, grounded in the Church's own teaching and commitments.

Why This Coalition Is Decisive

The environmental weight here is moral and global, so it acts through a worldwide community and its institutions rather than a local territory. That coalition supplies the faithful who can act in their own lands, the Church's movements that carry the teaching into action, the Vatican's offices that advance the example, and the Holy See's diplomacy that carries the moral voice into the world's forums. This is the form environmental action takes for a state whose weight is moral rather than territorial.

Finding and Building It

Begin with those who can act — the worldwide faithful, the Church's environmental movements, the Vatican's offices, and the Holy See's diplomacy — and widen to interfaith and international partners. Name the shared cause: the care of our common home, taught by the Church, exemplified by the Vatican, and to be lived by the community in their own countries. Sustain the effort by keeping the coalition connected, faithful to the teaching, and respectful of the governance, and by marking real steps: a teaching translated into action, an example advanced, a community moved, a diplomacy engaged.

STEP 4: MORAL, INSTITUTIONAL & EXAMPLE-BASED CHALLENGES — THE TEACHING, THE EXAMPLE, AND THE COMMON HOME

This is where a Vatican effort is realistically advanced — through the teaching, the Vatican's commitments, the worldwide community, and the diplomacy, with neutral respect for the governance. The levers are real but moral, exemplary, and global: they achieve the teaching translated into action, the example upheld, the community moved, and the diplomacy engaged — real if diffuse outcomes across many lands.

The Teaching and the Moral Voice

The Church's environmental teaching — *Laudato Si'* on the care of our common home and *Laudate Deum* on the climate crisis — carries moral authority to a community of well over a billion. The lever is to draw on it and amplify it: translate its call into real action across the worldwide community, amplify its voice on creation

and the climate in the world's conversation, and hold the Church and the Vatican faithfully to the teaching they themselves proclaim. How you actually do this: the Vatican office responsible for *Laudato Si'* is the **Dicastery for Promoting Integral Human Development** (humandevlopment.va), and the worldwide network built to carry the teaching into action is the **Laudato Si' Movement** (laudatosimovement.org) — over 900 Catholic organisations and thousands of trained volunteers. Bring the teaching to life where you are by joining or starting a **Laudato Si' Circle** (a small local group), or training as a **Laudato Si' Animator** (animators@laudatosimovement.org) to organise your parish or school.

The Example and the Carbon-Neutrality

The Vatican has pledged to become the world's first carbon-neutral state, acceded to the Paris Agreement and UNFCCC in 2022, installed solar since 2008, moved toward electric vehicles, and launched a large agrivoltaic solar plant at Santa Maria di Galeria (the *Fratello Sole* project) intended to power the whole state. The lever is to support and uphold that example — encouraging the completion of the solar and renewable projects and the wider greening, and holding it up as a model. Its weight is out of all proportion to the tiny state's actual emissions: the Vatican's own footprint is negligible in global terms, but the significance lies not in the tonnage saved but in the demonstration made — that an institution of the Vatican's visibility has judged the care of creation important enough to reorder its own energy around it. That is a beacon no small state's emissions could ever be: proof that the care of our common home can be lived, the smallest of states showing what it asks of the largest. How you actually do this: the concrete on-ramp is the **Laudato Si' Action Platform** (laudatosiactionplatform.org), the Vatican's own programme (run by the Dicastery for Promoting Integral Human Development) where a parish, school, diocese, religious order, business or family enrolls, commits to sustainability goals, and records a real plan — the structure that turns the Vatican's one example into thousands of local ones.

The Global Church and the Common Home

The true reach of the Vatican's environmental weight is the worldwide community it seats — well over a billion people, and a vast network of dioceses, parishes, schools, hospitals, charities, and lay movements across nearly every country. This is a reach no other actor in this series commands. The lever is to mobilise that community to act for the environment where they are — tree-planting, clean energy, stewardship in a hundred countries at once — to green the Church's own worldwide institutions, and to join with other faiths in the shared care of creation, so that a teaching proclaimed in the smallest of places becomes action in the largest number of them. How you actually do this, step by step: join or start a **Laudato Si' Circle**; become a **Laudato Si' Animator** (animators@laudatosimovement.org) to enthuse your parish and school; enrol your community — parish, school, diocese, order, or family — in the **Laudato Si' Action Platform** (laudatosiactionplatform.org) and log a plan of concrete steps (solar panels, tree-planting, waste and water); and mark the **Season of Creation** each year (1 September to 4 October) with prayer and action. These are the actual doors through which "mobilise the community" stops being a phrase and becomes solar panels, gardens and tree-planting in a hundred countries at once.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Aim the same grounding at each actor in the language that moves them, always faithful to the teaching and respectful of the governance.

- **For the Church's institutions and movements** — frame the cause as living out the Church's own teaching: here is the teaching, here is the action that answers it. Press for the teaching translated into action and the institutions greened.

- **For the Vatican's environmental offices** — frame it around the Vatican's own commitments: here is the pledge, here is the project or step that fulfils it. Press for completion of the solar and renewable projects.
- **For the worldwide community of faith** — translate the teaching into a call to care for creation where they are: here is the teaching, here is the action in your parish, diocese, and country.
- **For the Holy See's diplomacy and interfaith partners** — frame it around the moral voice in the world's forums and the shared care of creation across faiths, and press for diplomatic and interfaith engagement.

The golden rule: never misrepresent the teaching, never overstate the tiny state's own weight, and keep neutral respect for the governance. Credibility rests on a faithful grounding in the teaching and the commitment.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

With a landmark teaching, a carbon-neutral bid, and a worldwide community, media is a real lever — used faithfully and respectfully. The story is striking and globally resonant: *the world's smallest state, teaching the care of our common home and setting out to become the first carbon-neutral country, while a worldwide community of well over a billion answers that call in their own lands.*

Media does three things here: it carries the teaching to the worldwide community, holds up the carbon-neutral example for the world, and reaches the global and interfaith audiences drawn to the Vatican's outsized environmental voice. Match the channel to the audience — the Church's own communications and community networks for the faithful; global and environmental media for the carbon-neutral bid; interfaith and international forums for the shared care of creation; diplomatic and climate channels for the moral voice. Keep it scrupulously faithful to the teaching, handle all religious and governance matters factually and with respect, and let the landmark teaching, the carbon-neutral example, and the worldwide community carry the story.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Adapt every template — ground it in the teaching and the commitment, keep neutral respect for the governance, and frame it around the care of the common home.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request regarding [the environmental commitment / project] and its progress

To [Vatican environmental office / institution],

I am writing on behalf of [community / group] regarding [the carbon-neutral commitment / solar project / environmental initiative] and its progress. Grounded in the Church's teaching on the care of our common home, I respectfully request information on the commitments, projects, and progress, that we may support and share the example.

Respectfully,

[Name, community / group, contact]

8B: The Teaching / Moral-Voice Case

Subject: Living out the teaching on the care of our common home

To [Church institution / movement],

Grounded in the Church's environmental teaching, we respectfully seek to translate its call to care for our common home into action across our community — in our parish, diocese, and country. We ask your guidance and partnership. We attach our grounding.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: The Example / Carbon-Neutrality Case

Subject: Supporting the Vatican's carbon-neutral example at [matter]

To [Vatican environmental office],

We warmly support the Vatican's pledge to become the first carbon-neutral state and its solar and renewable projects. We respectfully encourage the advancing and completion of these commitments, and their holding-up as a model for the world. We attach our grounding.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: The Global Church / Community Case

Subject: Mobilising our community for the care of creation at [place]

To [diocese / parish / Catholic institution],

Grounded in the Church's teaching and the Vatican's example, we respectfully seek to green our own institutions and mobilise our community to care for the environment in our country. We ask your leadership and partnership. We attach our grounding.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: The Interfaith / International Case

Subject: Interfaith and international cooperation on the care of creation

To [interfaith / international partner],

Grounded in the shared care of creation across faiths, and in the Holy See's engagement with the international climate frameworks, we respectfully seek interfaith and international cooperation on the care of our common home. We attach our grounding.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8F: To a Church Environmental Institution

Subject: Partnership on translating the teaching into action at [matter]

Dear [Church environmental institution / movement],

We write regarding [the cause] and respectfully seek your partnership in translating the Church's environmental teaching into action across the worldwide community. We provide our grounding.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: The world's smallest state's bid to be the first carbon-neutral country

Dear [journalist / editor],

The world's smallest state teaches the care of our common home and is setting out to become the first carbon-neutral country on earth, even as a worldwide community answers that call in their own lands. There is a striking, resonant story here of outsized moral leadership, and we can provide the grounding and the human stakes.

Sincerely,

[Name, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: The care of our common home — in our country, as taught from the smallest of states

Dear friends,

The Church teaches the care of our common home, and the world's smallest state is setting out to become the first carbon-neutral country. Grounded in that teaching and that example, and with our institutions and partners beside us, we can care for the environment where we live — greening our institutions and answering the call to care for creation. Please join us: share what you know, and add your hands.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

When a moment is opportune — a major teaching or statement, a step in the carbon-neutral project, a climate summit, a worldwide moment of attention — triage to the fastest levers. Establish what teaching or example bears on it and what community or institution carries it, and reach the Church's environmental movements, the worldwide community, and the diplomacy at once. The teaching can be amplified fast at a moment of attention; the example held up quickly at a step in the solar project; the community mobilised through the Church's networks; the diplomacy engaged at a climate summit. Deep institutional greening is slower and continues alongside. Speed favours the prepared: know the teaching, the commitment, and the community before the moment comes.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

There is no tilted field of repression here; the challenge is different and must be named plainly. The environmental weight is moral and global rather than material, so the real difficulty is the distance between a landmark teaching proclaimed from the smallest of states and real action across a community of well over a

billion that is not of one mind; the gap that can open between fine teaching and its full living-out; and the singular governance, treated with neutral respect. This is not repression but a challenge of translating moral leadership into worldwide action — worked through the teaching, the community, the example, and the diplomacy.

Meet it not with confrontation but by patiently translating the teaching into action, upholding the example, mobilising the community, and building the coalition over time. You may see the teaching outrun its living-out and the community move slowly and unevenly — but the work is rarely wasted: every amplifying of the teaching, every step of the carbon-neutral example, every community moved to act is a real and lasting good, and the care of our common home is, land by land, more truly lived.

WHEN THE TEACHING OUTFRONS THE PRACTICE — HOLDING TO ITS OWN WORD

There is no question of the classic corruption other guides confront. The honest counterpart is the gap that can open, in any institution however well-intentioned, between fine teaching and pledges and their full living-out — the risk that the landmark teaching and the carbon-neutral commitments are proclaimed more than achieved. Its marks are specific and named respectfully: a teaching proclaimed but little translated into action; carbon-neutral pledges made but slowly fulfilled; worldwide institutions slow to green in line with the teaching.

The response runs through transparency, fidelity, encouragement, and example. Document the teaching, the commitments, and their progress faithfully; use the published teaching and the stated commitments to encourage their fuller living-out; use the carbon-neutral example and its progress to encourage completion; use the worldwide community to translate the teaching into action where the institution's own pace is slow. Holding an institution faithfully to its own teaching is fair and, here, exactly what the teaching itself calls for. Throughout, keep neutral respect for the singular governance, keep the focus wholly on the care of the environment, and never stray into the doctrinal or political — encourage rather than accuse.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, each feeding the others. Documentation builds the grounding in the teaching and the commitment; target identification aims it at the levers; the faith-institution-and-diplomatic coalition organises the community, the institutions, and the diplomacy; the moral/institutional/example work amplifies the teaching, upholds the example, and mobilises the community; and media carries the common-home cause. Run in parallel they compound; run one at a time they stall.

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the grounding in the teaching and the commitment; identify the teaching, the example, the community, the heritage, and the diplomacy; build the coalition. **Middle (months–years):** amplify the teaching; support and uphold the carbon-neutral example; mobilise the worldwide community to act in their own lands; conserve the heritage; engage the diplomacy and interfaith cooperation. **Later (years):** the teaching translated into action, the example advanced, the community moved, the diplomacy engaged — real if diffuse outcomes across many lands.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Advancing the care of the environment through the Vatican is genuinely possible, though in a way unlike any other guide. The Vatican is tiny, with almost nothing of its own to defend; the global Church is vast and not of one mind; the significance is leadership and example rather than any small state's emissions; and the governance is singular, to be treated with neutral respect. This guide has been honest about all of that from its first line. And yet the levers are real: the Church's environmental teaching (*Laudato Si'*, *Laudate Deum*) can be amplified; the Vatican's carbon-neutral commitment — net-zero by 2050, the Paris accession, the Santa Maria di Galeria solar project — can be supported and upheld; the worldwide community can be mobilised to act in their own countries; the heritage and gardens can be conserved; and the Holy See's diplomacy and interfaith cooperation can be engaged.

Hold both truths at once: real, effective levers of moral leadership, and the honest reality of a tiny state and a vast, various Church. The discipline is the same throughout — ground faithfully in the teaching and the commitment, amplify the teaching, uphold the example, mobilise the community, conserve the heritage, engage the diplomacy, and keep neutral respect for the governance. The care of our common home, taught from the world's smallest state and carried by its worldwide community, is worth every faithful effort — and turning the moral leadership of the smallest of states into the care of creation across the world is work the faithful, the Church's institutions, the Vatican's offices, and the Holy See's diplomacy can genuinely do. So can you.